

CHAPTER 10

CONVINCING THE CBI DIRECTOR

'We are terribly sorry.'

7December 1994. When I woke up, my hand was paining. Early morning, an officer came and introduced himself as Surendra Pal, deputy superintendent in the CBI. This appeared to be their custom: every CBI officer introduced himself, complete with designation, to all the accused. This helped me to a large extent, to believe that they, unlike the IB officers, had no hidden agenda. As I told my well-wishers later, the IB was framing a story, the CBI was finding the truth.

Surendra Pal was of fair complexion and medium build. He was unassuming, but spoke with the air of a man who had done his homework. I learned that he had met a lot of people in ISRO and outside to gather much information about me and the functioning of the organisation. In the course of his interactions, Pal had got friendly with some of my ISRO colleagues perhaps to glean more than what was told. During his short stay there, he said he had fallen in love with Kerala's greenery. But he missed the 'north Indian' food. Once when he told this to Mohammed Muslim, an ISRO scientist, Muslim supplied him a steady stream of rotis from his house.

This became news to a desperate journalist of a Malayalam newspaper who wrote that some of my colleagues were bribing a CBI officer with food. The source, obviously, was within ISRO; and this spoke of the internal petty rivalry that existed in our organisation.